

Formic Brand Guidelines

Positioning, voice, colour, type, surfaces and motion — the system behind the interface.

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What Formic is

Formic is an operations console for people running fleets of coding agents. It answers one question continuously: *what is the colony doing, and what needs me?* Repos, worktrees, agents, burn rate and context pressure all resolve into a single live surface an operator can scan in seconds.

The user is an operator, not a spectator. They may be watching seventeen agents across three repos while something is on fire in one of them. Every design decision serves that person — density over decoration, glanceability over delight, and a visual language that never makes them guess whether a colour means something.

Serious

People make consequential calls here. The interface earns trust by being legible under pressure.

Alive

The colony is always moving. The product should feel like it has a pulse, not like a static report.

Quietly distinctive

Character comes from craft — type, geometry, restraint — not from ornament.

Five rules that settle arguments

1 • Colour must mean something

Every hue in the interface belongs to exactly one job — identity, interaction, or status. A colour that decorates is a colour that will eventually be misread as a signal.

2 • Density is a feature

Whitespace is earned, not assumed. Never trade rows of visible state for breathing room; an operator scrolling is an operator missing something.

3 • Depth comes from edges, not fills

Surfaces stay white. Separation is a hairline border plus a soft shadow. Grey-filling cards to distinguish them makes the whole product look muddy.

4 • Personality lives in the calm moments

Logo, empty states, loading, onboarding — that is the budget for character. An alert row is never the place to be charming.

5 • Motion reports, it does not entertain

If an animation is not telling the operator something is happening, it should not exist.

How Formic talks

Direct, lowercase-comfortable, technically fluent. Formic talks the way a good senior engineer talks to another one: it states what happened, what it means, and what to do, without padding or performance. It never apologises theatrically and never celebrates routine success.

WRITE

3 agents waiting on you — cooper-scheduler first.

Context at 91%. This session will truncate soon.

the hill is quiet — nothing needs you right now

NOT

Oops! Looks like some agents need your attention! 🐜🐜

Warning: context window utilisation threshold exceeded.

No items to display.

Numbers over adjectives

"22k/min, 3× the 10-minute average" beats "unusually high burn".

Name the next action

Every alert ends with something the operator can do, not just a description of the problem.

Colony language, sparingly

Hill, colony, scout, forager, trail — fine in empty states and docs. Never inside an error.

Two brand hues, four status hues, one neutral

That is the entire budget. Everything on every screen is drawn from the ramps below. If a new case does not map to an existing token, raise it — do not invent a hue.



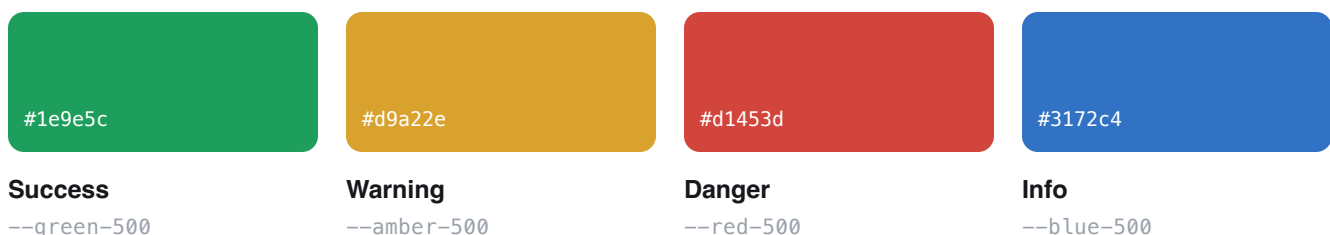
Clay — brand primary



Indigo — brand secondary / interactive



Graphite — neutral



Status hues are deliberately chosen to sit away from clay in hue space — clay is orange-leaning, danger is pink-leaning — so they stay separable at a glance. They are still always paired with an icon or label; colour alone never carries meaning.

One colour, one job

This is the rule that keeps a small palette from turning into noise as it spreads across a dense panel. Brand, interactive and status are three separate systems. No colour does two jobs.

Brand — clay

Identity only: the mark, the clay i, primary buttons, active nav. Never used to indicate state. If you want clay to mean "needs attention", you want a status token instead.

Primary action

Secondary

Interactive — indigo

Focus rings, links, hover and selected states. One consistent "this responds to you" signal across the whole product.

Focused input

[a link](#)

Status — green, amber, red, blue

Live, waiting, blocked, info. The only colours permitted to carry meaning, and never borrowed for decoration.

• LIVE

Working

Degraded

Waiting · Alert

Three faces, strict lanes

Syne 800

Display & wordmark

Logotype and page-level H1 only. Never body copy, never inside a data table.
Its width is the point — give it room.

Inter

Interface & body

Everything the operator reads: labels, rows, copy, buttons. 400 body, 500 emphasis, 600 headings.

JetBrains Mono

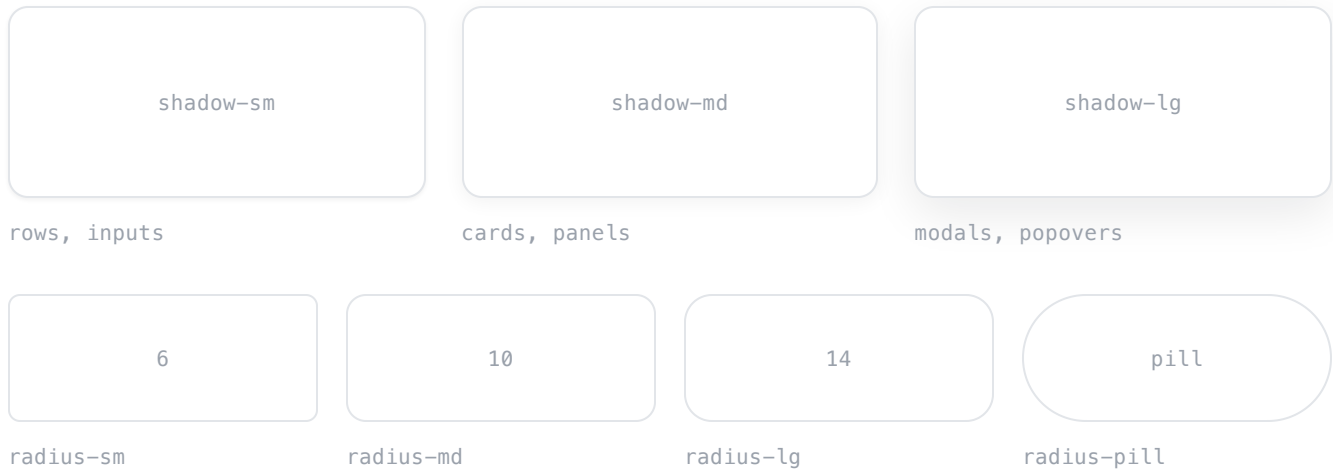
22k/min · 85.1M · sol-08-10

Metrics, paths, branch names, IDs, timestamps. Tabular figures keep columns aligned as values change.

ROLE	FACE / WEIGHT	SIZE / LH
Wordmark	Syne 800, -2.5%	—
Page title	Syne 700	28 / 1.15
Section heading	Inter 600	16 / 1.4
Body	Inter 400	14 / 1.6
UI label	Inter 500	13 / 1.4
Table row	Inter 400	13 / 1.5
Eyebrow / meta	Inter 600, +7% tracking, caps	10.5 / 1.3
Metric	JetBrains Mono 500	17 / 1.2
Path / ID	JetBrains Mono 400	11.5 / 1.4

White, with edges

Canvas and cards are both pure white. Separation comes from a 1px hairline plus a soft shadow — never from a grey fill. The single off-white in the system is reserved for things genuinely subordinate to a card: hover rows, inline code, nested panels.



Spacing runs on a 4px base: 4, 8, 12, 16, 24, 32. Dense regions — board rows, tree nav — use 8 and 12; page-level structure uses 24 and 32.

Applying the system

COMPONENT	RULE
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Header	Mark + Syne wordmark left; icon buttons and live status right. Status pill uses the success token, never brand clay, even sitting beside the logo.
Stat cards	White surface, hairline border, metrics in mono for tabular alignment. Card accent keys to what the metric <i>means</i> — a degraded health card takes the warning tint, not brand colour.
Board rows	Status pill (status tokens) and role tag (tag tokens) coexist on one row. A row can be "Guard" and "Waiting · Alert" simultaneously without the two systems colliding.
Role tags	Soft background + saturated foreground pairs, drawn from the tag ramp: slate, clay, indigo, amber. Classification only — never state.
Buttons	Primary = clay fill, white text. Secondary = neutral border. Status colour on a button only when the action <i>is</i> that status.
Focus	Indigo ring, 3px, 28% alpha, on every interactive element. Never removed, never left as the browser default.
Empty states	The one place to spend personality. Line-art hill, colony phrasing, muted neutral palette.

Slow, ambient, informative

USE	TIMING
Hover / focus	120 ms ease-out
Panel & popover	180 ms ease-out
Status change	240 ms ease-in-out
Live pulse	2 s loop
Logo signal	3.2 s loop

Ambient loops — the live dot, the logo signal, burn-rate trails — run slowly enough to read as a heartbeat rather than a spinner. Transitional motion is short enough to feel instant.

Never animate a value an operator might be reading. A number that counts up is a number that cannot be trusted mid-glance.

Every looping animation ships a `prefers-reduced-motion` fallback that resolves to the static state.

Non-negotiables

REQUIREMENT	STANDARD
Text contrast	4.5:1 minimum for body and labels; 3:1 for text above 18px. Every tint/foreground pair in the token file already clears this.
Non-text contrast	3:1 for borders, icons and status dots against their background.
Colour independence	Status is always colour <i>plus</i> a label or icon. Never colour alone.
Focus visibility	Visible indigo ring on every interactive element, keyboard-reachable in DOM order.
Motion	All loops respect <code>prefers-reduced-motion</code> .
Target size	24 × 24 px minimum for icon buttons, even in dense chrome.

New tint/foreground pairs must be measured, not eyeballed. At panel scale this is the failure mode that hides longest.

Two tiers, one direction

`formic-tokens.css` is the source of truth. Primitives hold raw values; semantic aliases hold meaning. Components reference *only* semantic tokens — `--color-brand-primary`, never `--clay-500`.

That indirection is what makes a future dark theme a remap of roughly twenty-five semantic tokens rather than an audit of every hex code in the codebase. Breaking it costs nothing today and everything later.

Do

```
color: var(--color-text-primary);
background: var(--color-status-danger-tint);
border-radius: var(--radius-md);
```

Don't

```
color: #16181b;
background: var(--red-50);
border-radius: 10px;
```